# Baseball Swing Mechanics Checklist & Coaching Guide

This guide covers key phases of the swing, providing checkpoints, common issues, and drills based on various coaching sources.

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## Pre-Swing Setup

### Grip

**What to look for:**

- Bat should be held loosely in the fingertips
- Door knocking knuckles should be lined up
- Avoid gripping the bat too deep in the palms
- Avoid choking the bat too much

**Coaching Tip:** Simplify the grip instruction, focusing on lining up the door knocking knuckles and keeping the bat loose in the fingertips.

### Stance

**What to look for:**

- An athletic position
- Feet usually about a bat's length apart, though variations (open, closed, feet together) are acceptable if the player is having success. Avoid trying to make every player stand the exact same way
- Correct distance from home plate: Player can reach out their front arm and touch the outside corner of the plate with the bat

**Coaching Tip:** Teach nice and athletic; don't "cookie-cut" every player's stance, especially if they are performing well. For younger players, simplifying is good.

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## The Load & Launch

### Rhythm & Load

**What to look for:**

- Player should have some rhythm or movement, not standing like a statue
- A smooth, controlled rock back as the pitcher gets ready
- The knob of the bat working back towards the catcher's face mask
- A small step forward (the stride)
- Feeling a stretch like a rubber band from the knob of the bat to the front knee
- Starting the load early enough to be ready to hit when the front foot lands
- Proper weight distribution - getting loaded and staying loaded while striding forward

**Common Mistakes:**

- Waiting too long and getting rushed
- Not getting loaded
- Getting loaded but falling forward early as the front foot comes off the ground
- Being too stiff or robotic

**Coaching Tips:** Encourage rhythm and movement. Use visuals like drawing back a bow and arrow or stretching a rubber band.

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Feet Together Drill:** Start with feet completely together and stride further than normal to feel getting loaded and fighting against falling forward.
- **Cross Foot Drill:** Cross one foot over the other before striding, fighting to keep weight back while moving forward.
- **Front Foot on Implement Drill:** Place the front foot on a milk crate, helmet, or medicine ball to put all weight on the back leg, then coil, pick the foot up, and control the movement forward.
- **Walk-in Drill:** Start in the back corner of the batter's box, take one step towards home plate, then take a full swing to create rhythm and looseness.
- **Skater/Step Back Drill:** From a normal stance, take a small hop forward, then a small hop backward before swinging to create rhythm and feel loading back into the rear hip.

### Launch Position

**What to look for:**

- Front foot has landed, player is in a nice, strong, athletic position
- Knob is pointed towards the catcher
- Hands are back in a strong spot
- Player feels balanced and athletic, able to field a ground ball from this position
- Player is under control, not rushing, with a window of time to decide whether to swing
- Head stabilization is key

**Coaching Tips:** Ensure players land in a balanced, athletic position. Emphasize controlled movement into this position.

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## The Swing Mechanics

### Sequence & Turn (Lower Half First)

**What to look for:**

- The swing sequence starting with the hips first, then the upper body and barrel working together
- Movement working from the ground up (tornado effect)
- Core engagement and rotation
- Avoid going with the hands early before the hips turn
- Maintaining posture and staying centered

- Avoid spinning backwards or falling back

**Common Mistakes:**

- Leading with the hands/arms
- Upper half starting before the lower half
- Spinning backward
- Coming up out of the backside

**Coaching Tips:** Emphasize swinging from the middle (hips and core), not just the arms and hands. Get kids to trust the turn. Use video to show them the sequence.

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Kickback/Scissor Kick Drill:** Start in launch position, feel like pushing back off the ground as the core engages and hips turn, helps with direction and avoiding spinning backward. Keep head still.
- **PVC Pipe Heel Down Hip Turn:** Hold a PVC pipe like a bat, get into launch (front heel up slightly), feel the front heel go down into the hips, and the core start to stretch. Watch for popping up out of the backside.
- **PVC Pipe Across Shoulders:** Hold a PVC pipe across the shoulders behind the neck, turn the hips while keeping the shoulders relatively closed to feel hip/shoulder separation.
- **Dumbbell Turn:** Hold a dumbbell, start with the hips turning, connect the top of the dumbbell to the shoulder and get to a parallel position. Focus on sequencing hips first.

## Connection & Bat Path (Inside the Ball)

**What to look for:**

- Barrel staying tight to the body, everything working together from the inside
- A short, compact swing, short to the ball and quick to contact
- Maintaining connection, avoiding distance between the barrel/hands and the body
- Back elbow staying behind the top hand in a strong hitting position
- Knob leading the swing in some aspects, especially for certain issues, but requires turning, not just pushing
- Barrel staying above or even with the hands at the connection/turn point
- Running hands across the chest to maintain connection
- Consistent bat path right above the ball, not steep. Aim for a level or slightly upward path through the zone

- Staying inside the baseball

**Common Mistakes:**

- Disconnected swing: Barrel/hands getting away from the body
- Casting hands out
- Back arm dropping early, leading to barrel loss
- Barrel working way uphill or dropping way behind hands
- Throwing arms or bat out
- "Dragging back elbow" where the back elbow leads and gets in front of the hands
- Swinging across the body
- Working out away from the body
- Rolling wrists too early
- Getting long or disconnected
- Pushing out or cutting across the ball (inconsistent path)
- Scooping at down pitches (golf swing path)

**Coaching Tips:** Explain what "connected" and "inside the ball" mean from a movement standpoint. Define terminology and cues clearly. Address the root cause of disconnection, which often starts in the load or initial move. Emphasize the feel of staying connected. For dragging back elbow, emphasize getting hips going first and then the knob leading.

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Connection Ball Drill:** Place a connection ball (or similar soft ball) between the front forearm/bicep and chest. If the player gets long or casts, the ball will drop, forcing everything to work together from the inside. Deflate slightly for younger players.
- **Bat on the Neck Drill:** Pin the bat between the neck and shoulder. If the bat comes off the neck early, it indicates disconnection.
- **Dodgeball on Back Shoulder Drill:** Place a dodgeball between the grip and the back shoulder. If the hands disconnect early, the ball falls out behind; if staying short and inside, it falls out in front of home plate after contact.
- **Turn to Slot/Connection Drill:** Use a low bungee cord attached to a wall, turning to feel the back elbow connection and getting into a stacked position.
- **Backside Barrier Drill:** Set up a wall or tee behind the back foot. If the barrel casts out, it will hit the barrier, forcing the player to stay connected on the backside.

- **Rope Bat:** A training tool that forces a short path and connection; if the player gets long or disconnected, the rope will fly off or the barrel will dump. Can be used with a rope bat on shoulder drill.
- **Fence Drill:** Set up with the knob at the belly button and the end of the bat touching a net/fence. Swing through without hitting the net to practice staying inside.
- **Two Tee Drill:** Set up two tees (front and back, aligned) to practice hitting through a consistent bat path right above the balls.
- **Tire Drill:** Hit through the middle of a large tire to practice staying through the pitch with a consistent path, avoiding cutting across or scooping.
- **Outside Tee Drill:** Place a tee on the outside corner, focusing on hitting the inside half of the ball to drive it to the opposite field (useful for situational hitting).
- **Mini Bat/Split Grip Drill:** Using a short bat or split grip can force the player to let the ball travel deeper and stay inside.
- **Knob Drill (for Dragging Back Elbow):** Focus on leading with the knob and replacing the front elbow with the knob as the hips turn, maintaining the barrel above the hands.
- **Rear Hand Chop (for Dragging Back Elbow):** Choke up on the bat, set the ball even with the front foot on a tee, and feel like chopping down on the ball with the rear hand. This is an exaggerated feel to counter the elbow coming up and barrel dropping.
- **Directional Drill (for Dragging Back Elbow):** Set a tee on the outer third, knee-high. Focus on taking the knob to the ball as the hips turn to get the rear hand in front and barrel in a good position, then turn through towards the opposite field.

## Tracking & Pitch Recognition

**What to look for:**

- Tracking the pitch from the pitcher's hand all the way in
- Keeping the head still
- Chin on the front shoulder at the start and chin on the back shoulder at the finish to help keep eyes still
- Understanding the strike zone (inside, middle, outside)
- Recognizing what pitches to swing at in different situations (e.g., middle to outer half for situational hitting to move a runner)
- Swinging at a good pitch
- Being ready to hit, mindset is "swing until it's not a strike" or "yes yes no"

**Common Mistakes:**

- Not looking at the ball or overdoing it
- Hard time tracking the ball all the way in
- Hard time keeping the head down
- Swinging at bad pitches
- Lack of pitch recognition

**Coaching Tips:** Train players to pick the ball up out of the pitcher's hand. Build confidence in pitch recognition. Teach players to be aggressive but also understand when to take a pitch. Focus on swinging at good pitches and having a plan.

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Mini Ball Tracking:** Use mini plastic golf balls or mini foam balls to train hand-eye coordination and tracking.
- **Pitch Recognition Drill:** Use two different colored foam balls (swing at one color, take the other). Or, line up balls across home plate (e.g., six locations) and have the player call out the location as the pitch crosses, then progress to swinging only at specific locations based on situation.

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## Contact & Extension

### Contact Position

**What to look for:**

- Hands in a Palm up Palm down position
- Rear elbow connected to the body
- Hitting the inside of the baseball
- Contact points relative to the front foot: Middle pitch slightly out in front, outside pitch in line with the front knee, inside pitch out in front

**Common Mistakes:**

- Rolling the hands too early
- Hands casting away from the body
- Getting alligator-armish or swinging across the body
- Incorrect contact point relative to pitch location (often due to timing issues)

**Coaching Tips:** Emphasize maintaining the Palm up Palm down position through contact and extension. Use tee work to practice hitting the correct points of contact for different pitch locations. Teach players to visualize hitting the inside seam of the ball.

### Extension

**What to look for:**

- Extending the barrel out through the ball
- Maintaining the Palm up Palm down position
- Avoid cutting off the swing
- Extension direction towards the center of the field or target

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Freeze That Extension Drill:** Take a normal swing but freeze with the barrel pointed towards the pitcher (or target) right after contact to check the Palm up Palm down position and extension.
- **Hitting Disc Drill:** Throw a hitting disc (or top of a bucket) with a Palm up Palm down attack; it should fly like a frisbee straight across, demonstrating proper extension and hand path.
- **Tire Drill:** Practices extending through the middle of the tire towards the center of the field.

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## Finish & Balance

### Balance

**What to look for:**

- Staying balanced throughout the entire swing
- Having heavy feet underneath them
- Finishing in a nice, balanced, athletic position
- Ability to stick their finish and hold their pose

**Common Mistakes:**

- Falling off balance
- Falling all over the place with their feet

**Relevant Drills:**

- **Freeze on Finish Drill:** Take a full swing and freeze the finish; challenge players to hold the pose without falling off balance.

- **Balance Beam/Line:** Have players step on a line or balance beam during practice swings to highlight balance issues.

### Finish

**What to look for:**

- A balanced finish
- Chin on the back shoulder
- Finish can be with one hand or two
- Some elite hitters focus on a shorter finish or deceleration out front to avoid flying open

**Coaching Tips:** Focus on balance first.

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## Overall Coaching Philosophy & Practice Implementation

- **Simplify:** Don't overcomplicate instructions. Less is more with cues.
- **Build Confidence:** Avoid constantly yelling corrections, especially in-game. Let players feel mistakes sometimes before correcting. Cheer them on. Focus on being on time, aggressive, swinging at good pitches, and having a plan; results like batting average will follow.
- **Individualize:** Not every drill works for every player. Evaluate players to identify their specific issues and choose drills accordingly. You don't need to change every single player to hit the exact same way, especially if they are successful.
- **Focus on Feel & Process:** Help players understand what the correct movements feel like. The feeling is different than just watching. Use drills to develop feel. Focus on the process (approach, mechanics, timing, pitch selection) rather than just results.
- **Use Video:** Video swings to show players what they are actually doing, as it may differ significantly from what they feel. This is crucial for building trust and making adjustments.
- **Identify Root Causes:** Look for the source of swing problems, often in the load or initial move, rather than just treating the symptoms (like a bad path).
- **Progressive Drills:** Start drills off a tee or soft toss and progress to front toss, BP, and eventually live pitching once the player can perform the movement correctly. For young players (e.g., 9U), start with simpler elements like hand position and stance, then introduce more complex drills gradually. Use shorter rounds in batting practice with focus swings instead of long rounds where players get tired.
- **Situational Hitting:** Teach players how to have productive outs, such as moving a runner from second to third by hitting the ball hard to the right side, often by focusing on middle to outer half

pitches and hitting the inside part of the ball. Use drills like outside tee drill or situational BP with targets. Pitch recognition drills are important for this.